preparations. Online news sources fill the silence, but the general feeling is one of utter official disarray.

One assumes that the army is getting ready to enter Gaza. That move could be terribly costly in human lives on all sides. We will probably know more very soon.

In his first declaration since the beginning of the events, the chief of staff admitted that there were many unanswered questions and much bitterness, “but now was the time to take the necessary measures” (and not to search for answers, if I may complete his declaration). General Herzi Halevi has indeed proven an ill-fated chief of staff, attacked constantly by the country’s Ben-Gvirs and their ilk, not defended by Netanyahu during times of relative peace, and now certainly held responsible for the army’s unpreparedness. There will be many commissions of inquiry when the time comes. Incidentally, Ben-Gvir and Smotrich are completely silent. They had better be.

A story shared on the radio: a woman, whose young son was spending time in the South, called him to see how he was faring. A voice answered her call: “My name is Muhammad. Your son is dead.” One of the 700. The number of Israelis taken as hostages or prisoners to Gaza has now risen to between 150 and 200. This will horribly complicate the retaliation.

There is something somewhat mysterious about the present situation: Israeli Air Force raids on Gaza, which have the potential to be extremely destructive, have so far been very mild, apparently on purpose. Hamas still has fighters on Israeli territory who haven’t been rooted out; all this seems to unfold on an intentionally minor scale. I know that some people think of treason. Instead, I attribute this to US pressure and, thanks to US or Egyptian brokerage, a promise from Hamas not to harm the hostages and prisoners held in Gaza if Israel abstains from drastic retaliatory measures. In short, an attempt to bring these events back to the level of the usual incursions and ordinary responses, if all sides keep to an imposed